8.2 EU and May/Johnson

Before the UK's formal departure from the EU, British leaders like Nigel Farage, Boris Johnson, and Theresa May levied sharp critiques against the institution, rooted in familiar populist grievances. Their opposition echoed themes of anti-elitism and the defense of national sovereignty, framing the EU as an overbearing institution that stifled Britain's autonomy. Central to the "Leave" campaign was the promise of regaining control—reclaiming decision-making power over trade, immigration, and the broader regulatory agenda. Many skeptics of the EU resented the influence of the European Court of Justice over British law[19] and viewed EU-imposed regulations as needless constraints on domestic businesses (Gomez Arana et al. 2019). They also argued for Britain's ability to negotiate its own trade deals, free from EU oversight. The financial contributions Britain made to the EU budget became another focal point during the campaign, with populist rhetoric suggesting that those funds could be redirected to vital domestic needs, such as bolstering the National Health Service.[20] This messaging found fertile ground, particularly in deindustrialized regions and economically struggling areas outside London and in the Southeast, where resentment toward the EU resonated deeply.

To advance their agenda, British populists employed a barrage of hostile rhetoric and political maneuvers. Figures like Farage, along with his UK Independence Party and factions within the Conservative Party, framed the EU as a bastion of elitism, detached from the needs and aspirations of ordinary citizens. They painted the campaign to leave as a battle against the establishment, leveraging public rallies, media appearances, and social media to amplify their message.[21] Their efforts culminated in the 2016 Brexit referendum, where a majority of voters opted to leave the EU, marking a seismic shift in Britain's relationship with Europe.

In response, the EU deployed several strategies aimed at mitigating the impact of Brexit while preserving its institutional integrity. Initially, it sought to appease the UK through concessions and reform discussions to retain its cooperation in key areas. Negotiations tackled issues like immigration, welfare benefits for EU citizens in the UK, and a reduction of regulatory burdens. One notable example was the 2018 "EU–UK Deal" (often referred to as "Cameron's Deal," alluding to Prime Minister David